WHAT IS LIFE?

Chapter 1

How many of us pause to understand the true meaning of life? We all live, but soon we die. The purpose of life is discovered by very few. Why did we come to planet earth? Why were we given this human birth? What is life all about? We breathe, but what makes us breathe? What is the Power that makes us walk and talk? How did this amazing creation of the human body come about? How many of us pause to ask questions? Do we investigate to Realize the Truth? When a child is born, we celebrate the arrival of a new life. But where did this life come from? We believe we are created by our parents, but is that true? No doubt there was an act of procreation, but what causes the fertilization of two cells to become a zygote that ultimately arrives as a little baby after 9 months? Who is responsible for all the magic that is happening in our mother's womb? How did our heart, lungs, kidneys and our brain form? Then the biggest question – Who gave power to the life that was born on our birthday? Unless we decode the mystery of birth and we understand the reality of death, we will never truly realize what life is all about. One day we will die, but who actually dies? The body dies, but people will say we passed away. Who died and who passed away? Where did the one who departed go? What happened to that life that was throbbing within? Why did the heart stop beating? What caused death, that moment when we lost our breath? Do we have answers to all these questions? The journey of life is commonly understood as the journey that begins at the moment of birth and ends at death. But what is life and where does it come from, remains a mystery formost of humanity. Very few people go in the quest to Realizethe Truth.

We believe in a God who gives us life, but we don'twho God is, where God is and what God is. We
believe in the fairy tale that we will go to heaven, but who will
go to heaven? Don't our loved ones destroy our body as they
burn or bury it? What do we all do? We pray, but we don't
understand what we say when we pray. We wish each other
good luck, but don't realize that life is not about luck. We
don't understand that everything that happens in our life is
the result of Karma, the Law of Action. There are Universal
Laws that govern the earth and control our life. Nothing
happens by chance. We have a choice to control our destiny.
But unless we go in search of the Truth, we will never realize
the true meaning of life.

Life is all about Karma. Karma means action. Everything in

life unfolds as a reaction to our own action. Just like the seed we plant decides the fruit on the tree, the deed we plant will decide our destiny. Our birth is the result of past Karma, just as our death will be decided by the Karmic law. Everything in life that is happening, is happening because of Karma, our actions. Unfortunately, we don't Realize the simple Truth –Life is Karma.

WHAT IS KARMA?

2 Chapter

The word Karma means action. But the world knows Karma more as a law – the Law of Action and Reaction. It is the Law of the Boomerang – What goes around, comes around. It is based on the principle – As you sow, so shall you reap. The Law is very simple. What you give is what you will get. Whatever you do, will come back to you. While the Law seems very simple, it is actually so complicated that nobody can decode the mystery of Karma in its entirety. Who created this Law? How does it unfold for 8 billion people around the globe? How does it control the reaction of every action? The Law of Karma continues to baffle humanity, and while we have no option but to accept it, not many of us understand how it actually works.

We know that the fruit on a tree, appears not by luck. It depends on the seed that we planted. That is why we don't find apples growing on mango trees. Just as fruits on trees depend on the seeds, whatever is happening in our life, depends on our deeds. But how does this happen? Who controls this? To understand Karma, one must go on a quest to realize the connection between life and Karma. One must pause and ponder on the magic of creation. One must understand the presence of the several Universal Laws that govern our planet. What causes day and night? What causes the earth to rotate on its axis, automatically, day after day, without any intervention and interruption? What causes seasons to unfold so beautifully? Why do dogs not give birth to cats? Everything that is happening in our world, is

governed by a law the creates order on earth. Even our death and our birth are controlled by a Universal Law - the Law of Karma. Where we were born, when we were born, and how we were born, was not our choice. But it is our own Karma, our past actions that decided our birth. Death is certain. Every 'body' will die. But who decides when we will die? Again, it is Karma. Not just birth and death, everything that is unfolding in our life is happening because of Karma, our past actions.

Karma is life and everything that unfolds in life. Those who Realize the Truth about Karma, make an intelligent choice to choose their actions. They realize that their destiny is in their hands. They don't blame God or luck for their miseries. They live their life doing good Karma, knowing that Karma controls everything. While many people around the world today accept the Law of Karma, and while the word 'Karma' which actually means action, has become synonymous with the Universal Law of Action and Reaction, a very few amongst us are fortunate to go beyond the common understanding of Karma.

It is a rare minority that not only understands that creating good Karma will ensure a good life ahead, but also realizes the connection between Karma and rebirth. They decode the mystery of how Karma will control their next journey on earth. But hardly anybody Realizes the Truth of how to transcend Karma, and how to be liberated from the cycle of death and rebirth and be united with the Divine. This is our ultimate goal – to realize we are the Divine Soul and to be free from all Karma.

HOW DOES THE LAW OF KARMA WORK?

3 Chapter

The Law of Karma is a Universal Law. Nobody can escape it. You may belong to any nationality, follow any religion, but you

cannot escape Karma. It is the law of the earth, and it starts at birth. Until you have breath, it controls everything that happens in your life, including your death. Whatever you do, good or bad, every action performed will come back to you.

People wonder who controls the Law and how it operates. Karma is one of the many Universal Laws that seem to be instituted by the Creator to keep the world going. If there is no Karma, then this amazing show that is unfolding on our planet would come to a standstill. Every day, we human beings wake up and we have to perform Karma or actions. They may be inspired by our desires and passions, just as they may be influenced by our morals and ethics. Nobody can escape from action. We have been created in a manner that we have to wake up, eat and drink, walk and talk, live and die. However, what controls our actions? We human beings have been given a free will, a power to choose. We have been blessed with an intellect that discriminates thoughts. We have been given a mind, the subtle part of our existence that triggers thoughts from our senses. These thoughts become feelings, that ultimately become actions. These actions are recorded, and they become the reactions that unfold as the circumstances in our life.

To understand how Karma works, we must question why things are happening around us the way they are happening. What causes everything to happen. Many of us think it is luck, fate, chance or serendipity. Some people think it is the will of God. We even pray for God to change our sorrows into joy. We don't realize that God is not micromanaging the millions of actions of the 8 billion people on earth. Everything is controlled by Karma. Once we perform an action, an inner mechanism within each one of us records the deed. It may be good or bad. But we have to pay for it. The law of Karma ensures that if it does not return to us during this lifetime on earth, then, it is carried forward into our rebirth.

An elderly carpenter was ready to retire. He had built many houses

for his boss. His boss requested him to build one last house. The carpenter resorted to shoddy workmanship and used inferior materials. When his boss came to inspect the house, he handed the key to the carpenter, 'This is your house,' he said, 'my gift to you.'

Therefore, everything that happens in life, happens because of our Karma. While Karma by itself means action, the term Karma denotes the Law which nobody can circumvent. Based on the principle - As you sow, so shall you reap, this Law makes no mistake. Just like it is in any game, our Karma seems to earn us a positive and negative score, which then has to be settled. If we have sinned, then, we have to redeem our sins, not in a distant hell but right here on earth. If our time is over, then we have to settle it by taking a rebirth. Therefore, we find some people being born in fortunate and some in unfortunate circumstances. This is neither luck nor God's Will. It is the Law of Karma unfolding. It makes us come back to the earth stage and the drama of life continues to unfold day after day due to Karma.

Karma controls everything that happens on Earth,
Whatever is not settled continues after Rebirth.

WHAT IS THE CONNECTION BETWEEN KARMA AND LIFE?

Chapter 4

Life is Karma. Unfortunately, if the human race understood this truth, they would live with grace. Today, we live with greed, and we don't just work to fulfil our need but we have desires and passions that make us crave till we reach our grave. The Ego thinks - 'I am responsible for my life. I can make the impossible possible.' What we don't realize is that every action of ours controls our life. We might have performed some actions in the distant past, even in a previous life, but they will not leave us. They will unfold as circumstances in our life and create challenges, even problems that will stop us from our dreams.

So often, we see people cry. They look up at the sky and question 'Why?' Why do bad things happen to good people? Somebody lost their job. 'Why me?' they question. Another is diagnosed with cancer. 'Why is God unfair?' is the question. Still, another loses a dear one. 'Why did death

have to choose my life partner?' that person asks. We human beings have questions after questions, as we watch the drama of life unfold. We don't have answers. We don't realize that everything that is happening in this world, is unfolding as per the Divine Law of Karma. Life does not unfold as per the wish of a God who is sitting in a distant heaven and passing orders as to what should happen in our life. It would be impossible to govern the world like this. Our life is the result of Karma.

If everything depends on Karma, then are we mere puppets? If everything is pre-destined as per our previous actions, then what is the point of this life? Those who understand the Law of Karma, realize that just as there is a past Karma that Karma controls our present circumstances, our present Karma or actions will control our future destiny. Everything is not pre-destined. But our past Karma is recorded in the diary of our life, and it causes our life circumstances, good or bad to appear. One day the body will die, but our Karma is not over. Karma does not belong to the body. The body is an instrument that performs actions and even experiences the results of our Karma. But the owner of the Karma is ME – the Mind and Ego. It is the subtle ME, that directs the body to act. So also, it is through the body that the Mind and Ego experience the rewards of its past Karma or is punished for its sins. One day, the body will die. But the ME, the Mind and Ego, carries the Karma forward into a new life. It is Karma that controls the continuous cycle of birth, life, death and rebirth. Everything in the cycle of life is controlled by Karma. The Karma may be our past Karma which is recorded and unfolds in our life, or it may be our present Karma, which is a result of our thoughts, our free will, and our actions.

Together, our past Karma and present Karma, become the deeds that act as the seeds that will result in our destiny. We control our own life. Through our actions, our Karma, we are the master of our destiny. Even our prayers to God, our deeds of love, compassion and kindness, become our good Karma that will result in our happiness. So also, our bad Karma, our sins, become the reason for our misery and sorrow. Not just today, Karma controls everything that will unfold in the future. Karma controls our life.

Life is Karma… everything depends on **Action**, Whatever is happening is just a **Reaction**.

DO WE CONTROL OUR LIFE?

Chapter 5

Those who believe in Karma, the Law of Action and Reaction, differ in opinion as to who controls our life. They do not understand how the Law of Karma unfolds. Are you in charge of your actions or is it somebody else? Each one of us is blessed with a free will. We can choose

what we do. We cannot choose what is happening around us, just as we cannot choose other people's action. We can choose our actions and our reactions. By doing so, we advertently control everything that happens in our life.

Shyam was a blessed man. It seemed like he was blessed with good luck. Everything he touched turned to gold. Every investment was successful. His marriage was blissful. His children were beautiful, happy children. When Raju, his best friend used to look at him, he used to be jealous. 'Why is Shyam's life so sorted? Why am I miserable in every aspect of my life?' Raju had a broken marriage and his disgruntled children had left him. He struggled to survive. While he felt he was smarter than Shyam in all ways, he had not learned about Karma, the Law. Therefore, he continued to ignore his actions and his life became more and more complicated.

Shyam believed in the Law of Karma. He invested his deeds to become seeds that unfolded in the destiny of his dreams. Even if something unpleasant happened, Shyam realized that it must have been his past Karma. He never reacted to it negatively. Instead, he accepted it gracefully and moved forward doing good Karma.

Just like Shyam and Raju, we all experience life with what seems like good luck and bad luck. We don't realize that there is nothing like luck. It is our own actions that control our life.

While we know we are in command of our deeds, we don't

realize that our life itself is unfolding as per our Karma, our

past actions. If only we realized that we were the masters of

our life, we would control every action, so that we could

control every aspect, every circumstance of life that is

unfolding.

Unfortunately, we don't realize that we cannot controlcircumstances. While we can control actions, we cannotcontrol past actions. Those deeds are already performed,either in a distant past, or even in a previous life, andtherefore, they must bear fruit. However, we are in commandof our present actions. These will result in how our future willbe. Those who understand the Law of Karma take charge oftheir actions, just as they take charge of their life.Instead of wondering why our life is what it is, we mustunderstand the Law of Karma. We must understand how it isresponsible for our joy and sorrow, for our birth and death,and for everything that happens in our life. Those whounderstand Karma, not only take charge of their

actions andtheir life but transcend Karma, to attain the ultimate goal ofbeing liberated from the cycle of pleasure and pain. Theylearn the art of going beyond Karma and being liberated fromsuffering until they are ultimately united with the Divine.Life is like a road...as per our past Karma, it is paved,But the present is like the car which can be swayed.

WHY DO WE CRY WHEN SOMETHING BAD HAPPENS?

Chapter 6

Because we don't truly understand the meaning of life, whenever something goes wrong, we cry. We look up at the sky and question 'Why?' We have not learned the art of acceptance and surrender because we have not discovered the truth that whatever is happening is happening as per our own **Karma**. Everything is fair. God is not being cruel or unjust. It is just the **Law of Karma** that is unfolding.

But most people don't understand this. They question - 'Why do bad things happen to good people?' They don't realize that bad things cannot happen to good people. The Law of Karma will not permit it. Whatever is happening, is just a reaction of our own action. Then, why should we cry? We must learn to accept whatever unfolds in our life. We must realize that if we keep doing what we are doing, we will keep on getting what we are getting. If we do not want to cry, then, we should not question, 'Why?' Instead, we must change what we are doing. Then, our life can change.

Our life is in our hands. We can make our life what we want to make of it. When things are happening around us, we must realize that these are the results of our past deeds. We cannot change these. We must accept. But we can change our present actions and so, we can control what is going to happen in the future.

Most of us don't realize that our future, our destiny is in our hands. Because of our **ignorance**, we are zapped by life, and we consider life to be a mystery. In reality, our life is unfolding as per our own **history**. It is our past controls **WHY DO WE CRY WHEN SOMETHING BAD HAPPENS?**

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our present, just as it is our present that will control the future.

Sheela used to constantly cry and complain. 'I am doomed with bad luck,' she would scream. 'God is so unjust, so unfair! Why should all the misfortune come in my life only?' She did not understand the **Law of Karma**. Sheela lived with the myth and would have died with it had she not met Mary. She was surprised when after a tragedy in Mary's life, Mary offered a prayer of gratitude. 'Thank you, Lord, for giving me the strength to deal with the tragedy that unfolds as per my past **Karma**. Give me the strength and the wisdom, to create good **Karma** for the future.' Sheela learned from Mary that one should not cry when something bad happens. Instead, it should be celebrated because our past **Karmic score** has been settled. We have redeemed some of our negative **Karma**. Hopefully, now our positive **Karma** will unfold.

Nothing in this world happens other than our own **Karma**, unfolding in our life. Neither must we cry nor must we question, '**Why**?' There is only one way to live a joyous and peaceful life - to **accept** the unfolding of **Karma** and to **surrender** to whatever will be. What will unfold will be as per the **Karma** we have already done. Now it is time for us to do **good Karma**, and to control our destiny. We must do our best and then leave it to **Karma** to unfold as the rest. We must learn that everything in life is **Karma** and nothing but **Karma**.

When something bad happens, we cry and question, 'Why?' Because of ignorance, we blame the Power in the sky!

7
Chapter

Most people believe that life is luck. They believe in fate and serendipity. They even pray for good luck to unfold in their life. Can you plant apple trees and then pray for mangoes to appear on them? Ridiculous! However much we pray, the fruit that will appear on the tree will depend on the seed that we plant, not our prayers. So also, the deeds that we plant will determine our destiny. It is neither luck nor prayer.
Many people believe in astrology and palmistry. They go to fortune-tellers and believe in the mysticism of a crystal ball. What they don't understand is that all this only adds to the confusion about life. Instead of making us focused on action, on doing deeds or Karma that will determine our destiny, we surrender our life to superstitions and myths which have no truth in them. How can the planetary positions affect the life of a human being, when man has not even been able to step

out of the earth? He gazes at the planets and assumes many things. Because of ignorance, he makes others also believe, and in turn, they lose sight of the Truth of Karma.
Those who believe in luck, show their palms to fortune-tellers and hope to discover their destiny with the 3 primary lines running across their palms. Their lifeline, their heart or love line, their money or success line, their marriage line are amongst the lines that people focus on and believe in. It is really unfortunate that we look at the lines of our hands and surrender our life to them, instead of using these very hands and the strength we have been blessed with, to determine our destiny. When will man realize that life is not all about luck? We must use Karma to pluck our destiny. Raj believed in all these fairy tales. He surrendered his life to fortune-tellers. Thus he lost control of his life. Instead of realizing that our life depends on our own actions, our own Karma, he wasted his life believing in these mysteries. He would spend hours gazing at a crystal ball, trying to see his future in it, rather than waking up and walking ahead to make his dreams come true. How can we look at a crystal ball and discover our future? How can a parrot pick up a card from a pack of printed destinies to reveal our future? Raj continued to lament about his bad luck as years passed, surrendering to fortune-tellers. He lived his life believing in horoscopes, rather than in Karma. One day he died.

Should we live like Raj and let our life be controlled by myths and superstitions? Should we not realize the science behind the Law of Karma? Is it difficult to understand that it is action that controls reaction, nothing else? This entire universe is unfolding moment by moment, not by chance, but by choice of our actions. Everything that happens in this life is like a boomerang. Don't we see that what goes around comes around? Still, we want to believe in astrology, in palmistry, in fortune-tellers and crystal balls and we lose control of our life believing in all these mysteries. When will we realize that life is not all about luck? It is all about Karma. When will we take charge of our life, rather than handing it over to fortune-tellers?

Many people believe whatever happens is luck,
They don't realize the seed they plant is the fruit they will pluck.

DO THOUGHTS

CREATE KARMA?
8
Chapter
Many people wonder about evil thoughts becoming sins. There is no doubt that thoughts are very powerful. Thoughts create feelings and feelings can become actions. But thoughts by themselves do not create bad Karma. They are not capable of interfering with the Karmic Law.

While many in the world believe that bad thoughts are equal to bad Karma, let us understand the simple logic. We get thousands of thoughts every day. Thoughts are beyond our control. If we permit these thoughts to become actions, they become Karma, both good and bad. However, we have been given the gift of intellect. The intellect is that domain which discriminates thoughts. It is that aspect of our life that permits us to choose what to do and what not to do. It is only a human being that has been given this free will, this choice and intellect. If we do not use this gift and we become a slave of our mind, then we are sure to let our evil thoughts become bad deeds which will plant the seeds to a miserable destiny.

Kamala had a crooked mind. She would not only become jealous about her friend's success, but she would take revenge at the slightest opportunity to get even. Her mind motivated her to do these evil deeds and Kamala suffered. Every evil deed, every sin, became a Karma that was recorded in her Karmic account. The Law of Karma makes no mistake. She had to pay back for every bad deed. Everybody could see Kamala suffer. But Shamala, her friend, had learned the art of not letting her evil thoughts become sins. Whenever a bad thought appeared, she would shoot it down with her intellect. Because there were no bad actions in Shamala's life, there was no bad Karma recorded. She lived a happy and peaceful life. DO THOUGHTS CREATE KARMA?

While Kamala and Shamala reveal how a bad thought in itself is not bad Karma, if we still doubt it, we can ask ourselves the simple question – If we have the most wonderful thoughts of helping others, being kind and compassionate, but do nothing about it, will these thoughts result in our destiny? A beggar used to trouble an old woman every day requesting for a chapati. The old lady had a son who had gone to war and had disappeared and she was very anxious and irritated. The beggar kept on asking for a chapati every day. One day, being frustrated she thought of putting poison in the chapati and ending this. Somehow her conscience inside stopped her from putting the poison. She did

not want to kill the beggar. After a few days, her son came back. He told her that he was on his way home when he was hit and badly injured. A poor beggar had taken care of him and had given him a chapati every day. The woman found out later that it was the same beggar whom she was planning to kill.

The Law of Karma is very clear. It is deeds, not thoughts! Just like people who talk, but who don't walk, achieve nothing, so also thoughts are of little use. Surely, thoughts influence action, but by themselves, thoughts do not create any Karma. We must pay a lot of attention to our actions. Thoughts are thoughts. They will appear. But just as they appear, we can use our intellect to make them disappear. Every thought does not become an action. Those who realize this, take charge of their thoughts, control their actions, and take charge of their destiny. They do not let their mind become their master. And so, they do good Karma and to their destiny, they reach faster.

The Mind is like a monkey,
jumping from thought to thought...
But Karma depends on action,
not thought, you forgot?

CAN WE CHOOSEOUR ACTIONS?

9 Chapter

Is man a robot who is controlled by remote control or does

man have the freedom to choose his actions? Unlike many

living creatures, man is free to be who he wants to be. Man can

do what he wants to do. Unlike a tree that is bound to the

ground, man has the liberty to choose his actions. He can

walk, he can talk, and he can go where he wants to go. But

once he does, he is responsible for his actions.

This is the reason that only human beings create Karma.

Animals, trees, birds or fish do not create Karma. While many

Eastern philosophies believe that all these living creatures are

experiencing their past Karma, one thing is sure, they are not creating any new Karma. Maybe a cockroach or a lizard is paying for its sins. But animals and other creatures do not have an intellect, a free will to choose their actions. Only man is blessed to choose his actions.

While man is blessed to do what he wants to do, he is also blessed to create Karma of his choice. It is a blessing no doubt because it is through these Karma that man can create a destiny of his dreams. It is through the choice of his actions that man can execute good deeds and stay away from wrong doings. Unfortunately, we don't realize this. We do not understand the true implications of the Law of Karma and we often blame luck for what is happening. We do not realize that it was our deed that became the seed that is now bearing fruit in our life. While our body performs actions, the Mind and Ego, ME, is the director of all actions. It is not only responsible for our actions, but it is also the recipient of the fruit of action.

If the deeds are settled in this lifetime, then we do not have to suffer them in a new life that the ME appears in a new body.

In the Law of Karma, living creatures are of two types - the doer and the receiver. All living creatures are receiving their past Karma. Nothing in this world is happening by chance. But what is causing whatever is happening is neither luck nor chance, neither serendipity nor destiny. It is not an authoritarian God sitting somewhere far in heaven, controlling everything by a Divine Bluetooth or wireless. Whatever is unfolding in the life of 8 billion people and in fact, trillions of other creatures is a result of their own actions. The

Law seems to be designed in such a manner that it is only conscious actions that become Karma. Any action that is not done purposely or consciously, doesn't come under the Law of Karma. Therefore, man is the only doer of an action, not other living species. Further, a man who is mentally challenged and who does not have the ability to discriminate thoughts becomes only the receiver of Karma. He doesn't do any Karma, because he is not choosing his actions.

Therefore, we must be careful in choosing our actions. Because, once we do, we have to pay for our deeds. Just like an arrow that leaves the bow cannot be withdrawn, it will hit its target, so a deed once done, becomes like a seed that is planted. It will bear fruit. Such is the Law of Karma! We cannot escape from it. We must thus be aware that our actions are the most important aspect of our life. Not only do they control our present circumstances, but they are also responsible for our death and for what lies beyond.

Man is not bound to the ground like a tree...
He has the willpower to choose to be free!

DID WE CHOOSE OUR BIRTH?

10
Chapter

Did you decide to come to earth? Whether you are man or woman, American, Chinese or Indian, Hindu or Christian - who decided the circumstances of your birth? We human beings do not stop to ponder over this most important question about our existence. Why were we not born as a dog or as a cat, as a bird or as a fish? Does our birth depend on our wish?

Some people think that birth is a matter of luck. It is by chance that we are born where we are born. But this is not true. Our birth is controlled by Karma. The Law of Karma records our deeds, our actions or our Karma, and the reaction to our Karma either happens during our life or if our Karma is not settled, not redeemed during our lifetime, it is carried forward to the next life. It is Karma that decides our birth.

Peter wondered why he was born in the Philippines, why he had such irresponsible parents, why he had to grow up in an orphanage after his parents fought and split. He questioned God on why he was given such a miserable life. Peter then learned about the Law of

Karma. He realized that it was not God who was to blame. It was his own past Karma. He learned that in his previous episodes of life, he must have created such Karma that decided his present birth and the suffering he was experiencing.

However, there was hope. While he could not reverse his birth and the circumstances of his upbringing, he could control his present actions. By controlling his present Karma, he could create a new destiny. While he did not choose his birth, he still had the opportunity to choose his present actions and his future destiny. Stop and reflect - why were you born where you were born?

How are billions of people around the world taking birth?

What is the mystery that unfolds on earth? It is not a mystery. It is a Law. Just like the Law of Cycles makes the earth rotate, day after day causing day and night, the Law of Action and Reaction too unfolds birth after birth. Nobody can escape from it. Not only does it control our birth, but it also controls our death. Our death depends on our Karma, our actions. Our body will die, but our Karma will continue in a new body as we, the Mind and Ego, ME that directs all action, does not die. When the body dies, the ME is reborn as per its Karma. Thus it is Karma that decides our birth.

The next time you see a newborn baby suffer, don't blame God. We are responsible for our birth, the circumstances of our birth, just as we are responsible for our actions, our Karma. Everything that unfolds, from birth to death, doesn't happen by magic. It unfolds as per Divine logic. Our birth is a reaction, actions of which were performed when we lived in another body. The body died, but the Karma was not redeemed. The only way to redeem our Karma, good and bad, is to take a rebirth on earth. Those who believe in the fairy tale of heaven and hell, must realize that what our parents and teachers tell is not true. Heaven and hell exist, but not far away in the distant skies. We experience them when we take birth, a birth that is decided by our past Karma.

Who decided your parents and the date you were born?

Indian, American, Hindu, Christian....

or that you are Sheela or John?

IS EVERYTHING PREDESTINED?

11 Chapter

Man is ignorant. He is so enamoured by the fantasies of astrology, palmistry, and crystal balls, that he fails to use his logic to understand the truth about life. He surrenders his life

to his luck and makes the astrologer, a god! If somebody can look at his palm and foresee his destiny, he is willing to pay any price. Thus he looks in awe at the magician who looks at a crystal ball and tells him what his tomorrow is going to be.
There is no doubt that some aspects of our lives are predestined. This is not magic. It is logic. We are destined to experience certain circumstances, but not because of chance. It was our choice of deeds, that became our Karma that will appear as our life. It is not luck! We pluck our destiny depending on the deeds we plant, just as we pluck a fruit on the tree, depending on the seeds we plant.
The question is - what is predestined and what is not? Is everything predestined or only some things? The following analogy will clearly explain the same.
Suppose you are driving a car. Is your destination predetermined? You may have a plan and you may be using a GPS to go where you want to go, but finally, the steering wheel is in your hand. You can choose to make the car go fast or slow, turn left or right. You can change your direction and choose your destination. But can you change the road? The road is already paved. You can do nothing about the road. If the road is blocked due to repairs, you have no option but to take another route. If there are speed breakers, you have no option but to slow down. Just like the road that we are driving on is already paved, and we can do nothing about it, our past actions or Karma, are already done. We can't change them. These past deeds will unfold, no matter what. These are predestined. They are like the road that appears in our life. We have to accept it.
However, our present actions are in our hands, just like the car. We can choose to drive the car the way we want to, just as we can choose to live our life and create a new destiny. By changing our direction, we can choose a new destination. So, by changing our actions, we can create the destiny of our dreams.

However, we must not forget that there are things that will happen in our life depending on our past Karma. Some things are predestined, and they will unfold. We have to accept. But we don't have to submit to what seems to be unfolding as our destiny. This is happening because of our past Karma. However, our present Karma is in our hands. By taking charge of our present Karma, we can, in a way, change a life that seems to be pre-destined based on our past deeds.

Therefore, we must realize that everything that is happening in our life is not predestined. We are the masters of our destiny. We can choose our deeds, our Karma, and we can

even change the effect of our past Karma. However, if our past Karma was deadly, it will be that much difficult to reverse it.

Is everything in our life predestined?
Are we just robots that live?
Or can we choose our actions and our Karma,
so that we can give and forgive?

CAN APPLES GROW ON MANGO TREES?

12 Chapter

Have you ever seen apples growing on a mango tree? You will read the question again and wonder if you have made a mistake in understanding it. How can apples grow on mango trees? It is just not possible! Whether it is in India or Africa, in Europe or America, only apples will grow on apple trees! Why? Because there is a Universal Law that states, 'As you sow, so shall you reap.' If you plant potatoes, you can't get tomatoes. While it seems common sense and we all understand the law of the seed and the fruit on the tree, it seems we don't understand the law of the deed and our destiny.

How often do you hear people lament - 'Why do bad things happen to good people?' It is so common to hear people cry when they see a sudden death, a disease or a disaster befall somebody near and dear. Sam was a very kind and gentle man. One night, he slept and never woke up. He was just 40 and he left his wife and 3 children without any corpus or support system. His sister Pamela cried to the Lord, and she questioned, 'Why?' This family was made of such good people. They would go to church every week. Not only would they pray, but they would take care of the blind, the orphaned, and the destitute from their modest earnings. Then, why did God choose them to face the tragedy of sudden death? Now, they would suffer poverty, insecurity and face the world with problems.

What we don't understand is that 'bad things don't happen to good people.' The Law does not permit it. If something bad is happening in somebody's life, it is because of a past deed. It may be a deed of the distant past, a deed done long ago beyond the recollection of our memory. It may also be a deed done in our previous life. The account of Karma does not finish at death. We carry our Karma forward, life after life and

we have to pay the price for the deeds not settled.
While there are many Universal Laws in this world and we have no choice or option but to accept them, we human beings continue to live in ignorance, not realizing the simple Law of Karma. Life is Karma. Everything in life is Karma. Nothing that happens in life can happen just by chance or by the will of the devil. When will we realize this?
While we seem to understand very well that apples cannot grow on mango trees, there is no possibility, still we don't seem to understand that bad things can't happen to good people, just as good things can't happen to bad people. The Universal Law will not permit it. However, our ignorance makes us live with thoughts of the rascal mind, making us believe that bad things often happen to good people.
If only we realize that the Law of Karma controls our life, we would pay more attention to our deeds, and determine our own destiny. We would go one step further to realize the essence of the Law and be liberated from all suffering as we will be free from all Karma and be united with the Divine.
Very few are blessed to reach the ultimate truth and transcend all Karma to be united with our Lord.
Is there any place on earth
where apples grow on a mango tree?
Impossible! The Universal Law won't permit it
and this we can see.

DOES THE LAW OF ATTRACTION ACTUALLY WORK?

13 Chapter

The world is enamoured by the secret of manifestation. We are made to believe that everything happens in this world through the Law of Attraction. But is this true? Let us analyze.

Suppose you are sitting in your car on a highway, and you manifest coffee, you imagine coffee, you think of coffee, and you even pray for coffee. Do you think a truck selling coffee will pass by and bring you the coffee of your manifestation? Absolutely not! If a coffee vendor does pass by, which is one chance out of a million, and you do get your coffee, it is not the Law of Attraction that is working, it is just the rare possibility or chance, or the low probability that is unfolding.

A law is different. A law will work every time for everybody. And therefore, to call the theory of attraction a law is wrong. What does attraction do? It creates a thought. It goes a step further and puts passion and power behind the thought. There are good chances that this will become a feeling and translate into an action. If we perform the right action, then the Law of Action kicks into play. Therefore, it is action and not attraction, that is a law. If you sit in a casino and keep on manifesting a jackpot, you will empty all your coffers and will lose all your money at the end of the day. The Law of Attraction does not work. The casinos of this world make big money by making us foolishly believe in the concept of good luck. They promote the concept of manifestation and make people hope that what they manifest will come true.

If you look carefully at the word 'Attraction', you will find the word 'Action' embedded in it. From AttraCTION, if you remove ACTION, what is left is 'ttra' - it is just some noise! Just as the word Attraction is nothing without the word Action, so is the Law of Attraction meaningless without the Law of Action. If there is no action, there is no question of us manifesting our dreams through attraction! Somehow, some philosophers have made us believe that we can manifest anything through attraction. Therefore, instead of getting our hands to work, we get our minds to think and hope those thoughts will make our dreams come true. There is no doubt that thoughts are important because they trigger feelings and actions. But if the thought does not become an action, the Law of Attraction cannot work.

The next time you want mangoes, don't sit in your garden and sing the song, 'Mangoes, mangoes, come my way! Apples, Apples, go away!' However much you may sing the mango song, your garden will continue to have apples, if you don't move from attraction to action. If you plant mango seeds, sure your seeds will bear fruit. Such is the Law of Action. The Law of Attraction may work, but only if it is complimented with the Law of Action. Those who believe in this secret of manifestation and believe that they can use attraction sleeping in their bed, they are sure to take the Law of Attraction to their graves when they are dead. We must wake up to the Truth that it is the Law of Action that works, not the Law of Attraction. The next time you are told of a secret or hear somebody talk about the Law of Attraction, make your voice heard that it is Action and not Attraction that will work. Maybe this Action will reap you some good rewards!

The Law of Attraction says,

you can make any dream come True....
But without Action,
can there be attraction... don't you get the clue?

****DOES KARMA BELONG
TO THE BODY?****

**14
Chapter**

As we drive down the highway of Karma, trying to understand where it goes, it is important to understand who does the Karma and whom the Karma actually belongs to. As onlookers to the law, it is the hand that does, that owns the Karma. Little do we realize that the hands are just an instrument of action. The hands are directed by the mind. If there was no thought, there would be no action, no Karma. Therefore, does Karma actually belong to the body or to the mind?

Those who have studied the Law of Karma, tend to believe that Karma belongs to the body because it is the body that suffers. A deeper look into this, questions the observation. Is it the body that suffers or the mind that also becomes miserable? To Realize the Truth, all this makes us delve deeper into Karma, the Law of Action.

No doubt, Karma means action. Without action, there is no Karma. But the action is only performed by the body. It is conceived and directed by the mind. Along with the mind, there is 'I', the ego. When 'I' want something, 'I' create a thought in my mind. The thought of the Mind and Ego, ME, translates into an action through the body. While it seems like the body is doing the action, we should not be deceived by what appears on the outside. Let us learn that Karma belongs to ME, the Mind and Ego. Not to the body.

How can we understand this Truth that Karma belongs not to the body, but rather to the mind and ego? The body acts and practically Karma should belong to the body as it also suffers 1984
altered, it had been actually destroyed. For how could you establish even the most obvious fact when there existed no record outside your own memory? He tried to remember in what year he had first heard mention of Big Brother. He thought it must have been at some time in the sixties, but it was impossible to be certain. In the Party histories, of course, Big Brother figured as the leader and guardian of the Revolution

since its very earliest days. His exploits had been gradually pushed backwards in time until already they extended into the fabulous world of the forties and the thirties, when the capitalists in their strange cylindrical hats still rode through the streets of London in great gleaming motor-cars or horse carriages with glass sides. There was no knowing how much of this legend was true and how much invented. Winston could not even remember at what date the Party itself had come into existence. He did not believe he had ever heard the word Ingsoc before 1960, but it was possible that in its Oldspeak form-'English Socialism', that is to say-it had been current earlier. Everything melted into mist. Sometimes, indeed, you could put your finger on a definite lie. It was not true, for example, as was claimed in the Party history books, that the Party had invented aeroplanes. He remembered aeroplanes since his earliest childhood. But you could prove nothing. There was never any evidence. Just once in his whole life he had held in his hands unmistakable documentary proof of the falsification of an historical fact. And on that occasion--

'Smith!' screamed the shrewish voice from the telescreen. '6079 Smith W.! Yes, YOU! Bend lower, please! You can do better than that. You're not trying. Lower, please! THAT'S better, comrade. Now stand at ease, the whole squad, and watch me.'

A sudden hot sweat had broken out all over Winston's body. His face remained completely inscrutable. Never show dismay! Never show resentment! A single flicker of the eyes could give you away. He stood watching while the instructress raised her arms above her head and-one could not say gracefully, but with remarkable neatness and efficiency-bent over and tucked the first joint of her fingers under her toes.

"THERE, comrades! THAT'S how I want to see you doing it. Watch me again. I'm thirty-nine and I've had four children. Now look.' She bent over again. 'You see MY knees aren't bent. You can all do it if you want to,' she added as she straightened herself up. 'Anyone under forty-five is perfectly capable of touching his toes. We don't all have the privilege of fighting in the front line, but at least we can all keep fit. Remember our boys on the Malabar front! And the sailors in the Floating Fortresses! Just think what THEY have to put up with. Now try again. That's better, comrade, that's MUCH better,' she added encouragingly as Winston, with a violent lunge, succeeded in touching his toes with knees unbent, for the first time in several years.

4

With the deep, unconscious sigh which not even the nearness of the telescreen could prevent him from uttering when his day's work started, Winston pulled the speakwrite towards him, blew the dust from its mouthpiece, and put on his spectacles. Then he unrolled and clipped together four small cylinders of paper which had already flopped out of the pneumatic tube on the right-hand side of his desk.

In the walls of the cubicle there were three orifices. To the right of the speakwrite, a small pneumatic tube for written messages, to the left, a larger one for newspapers; and in the side wall, within easy reach of Winston's arm, a large oblong slit protected by a wire grating. This last was for the disposal of waste paper. Similar slits existed in thousands or tens of thousands throughout the building, not only in every room but at short intervals in every corridor. For some reason they were nicknamed memory holes. When one knew that any document was due for destruction, or even when one saw a

scrap of waste paper lying about, it was an automatic action to lift the flap of the nearest memory hole and drop it in, whereupon it would be whirled away on a current of warm air to the enormous furnaces which were hidden somewhere in the recesses of the building.
Winston examined the four slips of paper which he had unrolled. Each contained a message of only one or two lines, in the abbreviated jargon—not actually Newspeak, but consisting largely of Newspeak words—which was used in the Ministry for internal purposes. They ran:

times 17.3.84 bb speech malreported africa rectify

times 19.12.83 forecasts 3 yp 4th quarter 83 misprints verify current issue
times 14.2.84 miniplenty malquoted chocolate rectify

times 3.12.83 reporting bb dayorder doubleplusungood refs unpersons rewrite fullwise upsub antefiling

HOW DOES LIFE
UNFOLD EVERY DAY?
15 Chapter

Have you ever wondered how actors perform in a theatre? Do they appear whenever they want, wearing whatever they want and speaking anything they want? Of course not! Everything unfolds in the theatre as per the storyboard of the producer and director of the play. So also, the drama of life unfolds as per a Divine storyboard. The only difference is that the storyboard of life is dynamic. It is constantly changing, depending on our present actions, our Karma. Along with our past Karma, the dynamic storyboard makes life unfold the way it does. Things don't happen by chance. If you think that you have problems and you have opportunities that are merely good luck, this is a fallacy in your thinking. Nothing happens by chance. Everything that is unfolding on the planet, has a Divine reason. That is why, the earth rotates around its axis precisely, once in 24 hours. Do you find that the earth sometimes spins faster and sometimes slower? This is enough of a clue to make us realize that everything in this universe is perfectly organized by Divine Laws.
The Divine Law of Karma unfolds in our life, day after day. The other actors on the stage perform actions towards us that complement our Karma, our past actions. Things that are happening are not a matter of chance. If something good is happening in our life, we can be sure that it is a good deed from our past Karmic account that is bearing fruit. If a tragedy befalls us, there is no need to cry and look up at the sky and

ask 'Why?' God is not causing it to happen. Karma is. We cannot escape the law. If there are bad deeds in our Karmic account, they will unfold as circumstances in our life.

DOES EVERYTHING DEPEND ON OUR PAST KARMA?

16 Chapter

Another question that confuses people is what all does our past Karma control? Some believe that everything in our life depends on our past Karma. Such people wonder, 'What is the purpose of life? If we are mere robots who are performing a puppet show and the string of our life is in the hands of Karma, then what is life all about?' They don't realize that everything in our life doesn't depend on past Karma. Karma works in a twin method. Our past Karma and our present Karma, together are responsible for what unfolds in our life, day after day.

Does it mean that past Karma is not important? Of course not! Our past Karma is very important. It decides our birth, just as it decides our death. But the concept of Karma itself is based on free will and choice. We have been given a mind to think and an intellect to discriminate. Thereafter, our thoughts and feelings crystalize into action. These actions are recorded in our Karmic account. Can these present actions undo sins of the past? Yes, they possibly can. The Creator has given us an opportunity to undo our deeds by doing good deeds.

Therefore, we must learn that past Karma is changeable, provided our present Karma is strong enough to undo the past deeds. If not, then the past Karma will dominate in our life. It will seem like we are continuing to suffer because of bad luck or we do not have God's grace, when in reality, it is our own past Karma returning to us.

Charlie lived a miserable life. He learned all about Karma and tried to do as much good as he could to as many people in as many ways.

happened to be necessary in any particular number of 'The Times' had been assembled and collated, that number would be reprinted, the original copy destroyed, and the corrected copy placed on the files in its stead. This process of continuous alteration was applied not only to newspapers, but to books, periodicals, pamphlets, posters, leaflets, films, sound-tracks, cartoons, photographs-to every kind of literature or documentation which might conceivably hold any political or ideological significance. Day by day and almost minute by minute the past was brought up to date. In this way every prediction made by the Party could be shown by documentary evidence to have been correct, nor was any item of news, or any expression of opinion, which conflicted with the needs of the moment, ever allowed to remain on record. All history was a palimpsest, scraped clean and reinscribed exactly as often as was necessary. In no case

would it have been possible, once the deed was done, to prove that any falsification had taken place. The largest section of the Records Department, far larger than the one on which Winston worked, consisted simply of persons whose duty it was to track down and collect all copies of books, newspapers, and other documents which had been superseded and were due for destruction. A number of 'The Times' which might, because of changes in political alignment, or mistaken prophecies uttered by Big Brother, have been rewritten a dozen times still stood on the files bearing its original date, and no other copy existed to contradict it. Books, also, were recalled and rewritten again and again, and were invariably reissued without any admission that any alteration had been made. Even the written instructions which Winston received, and which he invariably got rid of as soon as he had dealt with them, never stated or implied that an act of forgery was to be committed: always the reference was to slips, errors, misprints, or misquotations which it was necessary to put right in the interests of accuracy.

But actually, he thought as he readjusted the Ministry of Plenty's figures, it was not even forgery. It was merely the substitution of one piece of nonsense for another. Most of the material that you were dealing with had no connexion with anything in the real world, not even the kind of connexion that is contained in a direct lie. Statistics were just as much a fantasy in their original version as in their rectified version. A great deal of the time you were expected to make them up out of your head. For example, the Ministry of Plenty's forecast had estimated the output of boots for the quarter at 145 million pairs. The actual output was given as sixty-two millions. Winston, however, in rewriting the forecast, marked the figure down to fifty-seven millions, so as to allow for the usual claim that the quota had been overfulfilled. In any case, sixty-two millions was no nearer the truth than fifty-seven millions, or than 145 millions. Very likely no boots.

He sat back in his chair, slightly ashamed of himself, and laid down the pen. The next moment he started violently. There was a knocking at the door.

Already! He sat as still as a mouse, in the futile hope that whoever it was might go away after a single attempt. But no, the knocking was repeated. The worst thing of all would be to delay. His heart was thumping like a drum, but his face, from long habit, was probably expressionless. He got up and moved heavily towards the door.

2

As he put his hand to the door-knob Winston saw that he had left the diary open on the table. DOWN WITH BIG BROTHER was written all over it, in letters almost big enough to be legible across the room. It was an inconceivably stupid thing to have done. But, he realized, even in his panic he had not wanted to smudge the creamy paper by shutting the book while the ink was wet.

He drew in his breath and opened the door. Instantly a warm wave of relief flowed through him. A colourless, crushed-looking woman, with wispy hair and a lined face, was

standing outside.
'Oh, comrade,' she began in a dreary, whining sort of voice, 'I thought I heard you come in. Do you think you could come across and have a look at our kitchen sink? It's got blocked up and--'
It was Mrs Parsons, the wife of a neighbour on the same floor. ('Mrs' was a word somewhat discountenanced by the Party-you were supposed to call everyone 'comrade'-but with some women one used it instinctively.) She was a woman of about thirty, but looking much older. One had the impression that there was dust in the creases of her face. Winston followed her down the passage. These amateur repair jobs were an almost daily irritation. Victory Mansions were old flats, built in 1930 or thereabouts, and were falling to pieces. The plaster flaked constantly from ceilings and walls, the pipes burst in every hard frost, the roof leaked whenever there was snow, the heating system was usually running at half steam when it was not closed down altogether from motives of economy. Repairs, except what you could do for yourself, had to be sanctioned by remote committees which were liable to hold up even the mending of a window-pane for two years.

The sting of the catapult bullet had worn off. He picked up his pen halfheartedly, wondering whether he could find something more to write in the diary. Suddenly he began thinking of O'Brien again.
Years ago-how long was it? Seven years it must be-he had dreamed that he was walking through a pitch-dark room. And someone sitting to one side of him had said as he passed: 'We shall meet in the place where there is no darkness.' It was said very quietly, almost casually-a statement, not a command. He had walked on without pausing. What was curious was that at the time, in the dream, the words had not made much impression on him. It was only later and by degrees that they had seemed to take on significance. He could not now remember whether it was before or after having the dream that he had seen O'Brien for the first time, nor could he remember when he had first identified the voice as O'Brien's. But at any rate the identification existed. It was O'Brien who had spoken to him out of the dark.
Winston had never been able to feel sure-even after this morning's flash of the eyes it was still impossible to be sure whether O'Brien was a friend or an enemy. Nor did it even seem to matter greatly. There was a link of understanding between them, more important than affection or partisanship. 'We shall meet in the place where there is no darkness,' he had said. Winston did not know what it meant, only that in some way or

another it would come true.
The voice from the telescreen paused. A trumpet call, clear and beautiful, floated into the stagnant air. The voice continued raspingly:
'Attention! Your attention, please! A newsflash has this moment arrived from the Malabar front. Our forces in South India have won a glorious victory. I am authorized to say that the action we are now reporting may well bring the war within measurable distance of its end. Here is the newsflash--'
Bad news coming, thought Winston. And sure enough, following on a gory description of the annihilation of a Eurasian army, with stupendous figures of killed and prisoners, came the announcement that, as from next week, the chocolate ration would be reduced from thirty grammes to twenty.
Winston belched again. The gin was wearing off, leaving a deflated feeling. The telescreen-perhaps to celebrate the victory, perhaps to drown the memory of the lost chocolate-crashed into 'Oceania, 'tis for thee'. You were supposed to stand to attention. However, in his present position he was invisible.

delirium, but this sub-human chanting of 'B-B!...B-B!' always filled him with horror. Of course he chanted with the rest: it was impossible to do otherwise. To dissemble your feelings, to control your face, to do what everyone else was doing, was an instinctive reaction. But there was a space of a couple of seconds during which the expression of his eyes might conceivably have betrayed him. And it was exactly at this moment that the significant thing happened—if, indeed, it did happen.
Momentarily he caught O'Brien's eye. O'Brien had stood up. He had taken off his spectacles and was in the act of resettling them on his nose with his characteristic gesture. But there was a fraction of a second when their eyes met, and for as long as it took to happen Winston knew—yes, he KNEW!—that O'Brien was thinking the same thing as himself. An unmistakable message had passed. It was as though their two minds had opened and the thoughts were flowing from one into the other through their eyes. 'I am with you,' O'Brien seemed to be saying to him. 'I know precisely what you are feeling. I know all about your contempt, your hatred, your disgust. But don't worry, I am on your side!' And then the flash of intelligence was gone, and O'Brien's face was as inscrutable as everybody else's.
That was all, and he was already uncertain whether it had happened. Such incidents never had any sequel. All that they did was to keep alive in him the belief, or

hope, that others besides himself were the enemies of the Party. Perhaps the rumours of vast underground conspiracies were true after all—perhaps the Brotherhood really existed! It was impossible, in spite of the endless arrests and confessions and executions, to be sure that the Brotherhood was not simply a myth. Some days he believed in it, some days not. There was no evidence, only fleeting glimpses that might mean anything or nothing: snatches of overheard conversation, faint scribbles on lavatory walls—once, even, when two strangers met, a small movement of the hand which had looked as though it might be a signal of recognition. It was all guesswork: very likely he had imagined everything. He had gone back to his cubicle without looking at O'Brien again. The idea of following up their momentary contact hardly crossed his mind. It would have been inconceivably dangerous even if he had known how to set about doing it. For a second, two seconds, they had exchanged an equivocal glance, and that was the end of the story. But even that was a memorable event, in the locked loneliness in which one had to live.

Winston roused himself and sat up straighter. He let out a belch. The gin was rising from his stomach.

14

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'Why can't we go and see the hanging?' roared the boy in his huge voice.

'Want to see the hanging! Want to see the hanging!' chanted the little girl, still capering round.

Some Eurasian prisoners, guilty of war crimes, were to be hanged in the Park that evening, Winston remembered. This happened about once a month, and was a popular spectacle. Children always clamoured to be taken to see it. He took his leave of Mrs Parsons and made for the door. But he had not gone six steps down the passage when something hit the back of his neck an agonizingly painful blow. It was as though a red-hot wire had been jabbed into him. He spun round just in time to see Mrs Parsons dragging her son back into the doorway while the boy pocketed a catapult.

'Goldstein!' bellowed the boy as the door closed on him. But what most struck Winston was the look of helpless fright on the woman's greyish face.

Back in the flat he stepped quickly past the telescreen and sat down at the table again, still rubbing his neck. The music from the telescreen had stopped. Instead, a clipped military voice was reading out, with a sort of brutal relish, a description of the armaments of the new Floating Fortress which had just been anchored between Iceland and the Faroe Islands.

With those children, he thought, that wretched woman must lead a life of terror.

Another year, two years, and they would be watching her night and day for symptoms of unorthodoxy. Nearly all children nowadays were horrible. What was worst of all was that by means of such organizations as the Spies they were systematically turned into ungovernable little savages, and yet this produced in them no tendency whatever to rebel against the discipline of the Party. On the contrary, they adored the Party and everything connected with it. The songs, the processions, the banners, the hiking, the drilling with dummy rifles, the yelling of slogans, the worship of Big Brother-it was all a sort of glorious game to them. All their ferocity was turned outwards, against the enemies of the State, against foreigners, traitors, saboteurs, thoughtcriminals. It was almost normal for people over thirty to be frightened of their own children. And with good reason, for hardly a week passed in which "The Times' did not carry a paragraph describing how some eavesdropping little sneak-'child hero' was the phrase generally used-had overheard some compromising remark and denounced its parents to the Thought Police.

His eyes re-focused on the page. He discovered that while he sat helplessly musing he had also been writing, as though by automatic action. And it was no longer the same cramped, awkward handwriting as before. His pen had slid voluptuously over the smooth paper, printing in large neat capitals–DOWN WITH BIG BROTHER DOWN WITH BIG BROTHER DOWN WITH BIG BROTHER DOWN WITH BIG BROTHER DOWN WITH
BIG BROTHER

over and over again, filling half a page.

He could not help feeling a twinge of panic. It was absurd, since the writing of those particular words was not more dangerous than the initial act of opening the diary, but for a moment he was tempted to tear out the spoiled pages and abandon the enterprise altogether.

He did not do so, however, because he knew that it was useless. Whether he wrote DOWN WITH BIG BROTHER, or whether he refrained from writing it, made no difference. Whether he went on with the diary, or whether he did not go on with it, made no difference. The Thought Police would get him just the same. He had committed—would still have committed, even if he had never set pen to paper—the essential crime that contained all others in itself. Thoughtcrime, they called it. Thoughtcrime was not a thing that could be concealed for ever. You might dodge successfully for a while, even for years, but sooner or later they were bound to get you.

It was always at night—the arrests invariably happened at night. The sudden jerk out of sleep, the rough hand shaking your shoulder, the lights glaring in your eyes, the ring of hard faces round the bed. In the vast majority of cases there was no trial, no report of the arrest. People simply disappeared, always during the night. Your name was removed from the registers, every record of everything you had ever done was wiped out, your one-time existence was denied and then forgotten. You were abolished, annihilated: VAPORIZED was the usual word.

For a moment he was seized by a kind of hysteria. He began writing in a hurried untidy scrawl:

theyll shoot me i don’t care theyll shoot me in the back of the neck i dont care down with big brother they always shoot you in the back of the neck i dont care down with big brother---

19

1984

In its second minute the Hate rose to a frenzy. People were leaping up and down in their places and shouting at the tops of their voices in an effort to drown the maddening bleating voice that came from the screen. The little sandy-haired woman had turned bright pink, and her mouth was opening and shutting like that of a landed fish. Even O'Brien's heavy face was flushed. He was sitting very straight in his chair, his powerful chest swelling and quivering as though he were standing up to the assault of a wave. The dark-haired girl behind Winston had begun crying out 'Swine! Swine! Swine!' and suddenly she picked up a heavy Newspeak dictionary and flung it at the screen. It struck Goldstein's nose and bounced off; the voice continued inexorably. In a lucid moment Winston found that he was shouting with the others and kicking his heel violently against the rung of his chair. The horrible thing about the Two Minutes Hate was not that one was obliged to act a part, but, on the contrary, that it was impossible to avoid joining in. Within thirty seconds any pretence was always unnecessary. A hideous ecstasy of fear and vindictiveness, a desire to kill, to torture, to smash faces in with a sledge-hammer, seemed to flow through the whole group of people like an electric current, turning one even against one's will into a grimacing, screaming lunatic. And yet the rage that one felt was an abstract, undirected emotion which could be switched from one object to another like the flame of a blowlamp. Thus, at one moment Winston's hatred was not turned against Goldstein at all, but, on the contrary, against Big Brother, the Party, and the Thought Police; and at such moments his heart went out to the lonely,

derided heretic on the screen, sole guardian of truth and sanity in a world of lies. And yet the very next instant he was at one with the people about him, and all that was said of Goldstein seemed to him to be true. At those moments his secret loathing of Big Brother changed into adoration, and Big Brother seemed to tower up, an invincible, fearless protector, standing like a rock against the hordes of Asia, and Goldstein, in spite of his isolation, his helplessness, and the doubt that hung about his very existence, seemed like some sinister enchanter, capable by the mere power of his voice of wrecking the structure of civilization.

It was even possible, at moments, to switch one's hatred this way or that by a voluntary act. Suddenly, by the sort of violent effort with which one wrenches one's head away from the pillow in a nightmare, Winston succeeded in transferring his hatred from the face on the screen to the dark-haired girl behind him. Vivid, beautiful hallucinations flashed through his mind. He would flog her to death with a rubber truncheon. He would tie her naked to a stake and shoot her full of arrows like Saint Sebastian. He would ravish her and cut her throat at the moment of climax. Better than before, moreover, he realized

WHY it was that he hated her. He hated her because she was young and pretty and sexless, because he wanted to go to bed with her and would never do so, because round her sweet supple waist, which seemed to ask you to encircle it with your arm, there was only the odious scarlet sash, aggressive symbol of chastity.

The Hate rose to its climax. The voice of Goldstein had become an actual sheep's bleat, and for an instant the face changed into that of a sheep. Then the sheep-face melted into the figure of a Eurasian soldier who seemed to be advancing, huge and terrible, his submachine gun roaring, and seeming to spring out of the surface of the screen, so that some of the people in the front row actually flinched backwards in their seats. But in the same moment, drawing a deep sigh of relief from everybody, the hostile figure melted into the face of Big Brother, black-haired, blackmoustachio'd, full of power and mysterious calm, and so vast that it almost filled up the screen. Nobody heard what Big Brother was saying. It was merely a few words of encouragement, the sort of words that are uttered in the din of battle, not distinguishable individually but restoring confidence by the fact of being spoken. Then the face of Big Brother faded away again, and instead the three slogans of the Party stood out in bold capitals:

WAR IS PEACE
FREEDOM IS SLAVERY
IGNORANCE IS STRENGTH

But the face of Big Brother seemed to persist for several seconds on the screen, as

though the impact that it had made on everyone's eyeballs was too vivid to wear off immediately. The little sandy-haired woman had flung herself forward over the back of the chair in front of her. With a tremulous murmur that sounded like 'My Saviour!' she extended her arms towards the screen. Then she buried her face in her hands. It was apparent that she was uttering a prayer.

At this moment the entire group of people broke into a deep, slow, rhythmical chant of 'B-B!...B-B!'-over and over again, very slowly, with a long pause between the first 'B' and the second-a heavy, murmurous sound, somehow curiously savage, in the background of which one seemed to hear the stamp of naked feet and the throbbing of tom-toms. For perhaps as much as thirty seconds they kept it up. It was a refrain that was often heard in moments of overwhelming emotion. Partly it was a sort of hymn to the wisdom and majesty of Big Brother, but still more it was an act of self-hypnosis, a deliberate drowning of consciousness by means of rhythmic noise. Winston's entrails seemed to grow cold. In the Two Minutes Hate he could not help sharing in the general

The waist, an exercise that was supposed to be good for the back muscles)—the frightening thing was that it might all be true. If the Party could thrust its hand into the past and say of this or that event, IT NEVER HAPPENED—that, surely, was more terrifying than mere torture and death?

The Party said that Oceania had never been in alliance with Eurasia. He, Winston Smith, knew that Oceania had been in alliance with Eurasia as short a time as four years ago. But where did that knowledge exist? Only in his own consciousness, which in any case must soon be annihilated. And if all others accepted the lie which the Party imposed—if all records told the same tale—then the lie passed into history and became truth. ‘Who controls the past,’ ran the Party slogan, ‘controls the future: who controls the present controls the past.’ And yet the past, though of its nature alterable, never had been altered. Whatever was true now was true from everlasting to everlasting. It was quite simple. All that was needed was an unending series of victories over your own memory. ‘Reality control’, they called it: in Newspeak, ‘doublethink’.

‘Stand easy!’ barked the instructress, a little more genially.

Winston sank his arms to his sides and slowly refilled his lungs with air. His mind slid away into the labyrinthine world of doublethink. To know and not to know, to be conscious of complete truthfulness while telling carefully constructed lies, to hold simultaneously two opinions which cancelled out, knowing them to be contradictory and believing in both of them, to use logic against logic, to repudiate morality while laying claim to it, to believe that democracy was impossible and that the Party was the guardian of democracy, to forget whatever it was necessary to forget, then to draw it back into

memory again at the moment when it was needed, and then promptly to forget it again: and above all, to apply the same process to the process itself. That was the ultimate subtlety: consciously to induce unconsciousness, and then, once again, to become unconscious of the act of hypnosis you had just performed. Even to understand the word ‘doublethink’ involved the use of doublethink.

The instructress had called them to attention again. ‘And now let’s see which of us can touch our toes!’ she said enthusiastically. ‘Right over from the hips, please, comrades. ONE-two! ONE-two!…’

Winston loathed this exercise, which sent shooting pains all the way from his heels to his buttocks and often ended by bringing on another coughing fit. The half-pleasant quality went out of his meditations. The past, he reflected, had not merely been

There were people sitting all over the stone-flagged floor, and other people, packed tightly together, were sitting on metal bunks, one above the other. Winston and his mother and father found themselves a place on the floor, and near them an old man and an old woman were sitting side by side on a bunk. The old man had on a decent dark suit and a black cloth cap pushed back from very white hair: his face was scarlet and his eyes were blue and full of tears. He reeked of gin. It seemed to breathe out of his skin in place of sweat, and one could have fancied that the tears welling from his eyes were pure gin. But though slightly drunk he was also suffering under some grief that was genuine and unbearable. In his childish way Winston grasped that some terrible thing, something that was beyond forgiveness and could never be remedied, had just happened. It also seemed to him that he knew what it was. Someone whom the old man loved—a little granddaughter, perhaps—had been killed. Every few minutes the old man kept repeating:

'We didn't ought to 'ave trusted 'em. I said so, Ma, didn't I? That's what comes of trusting 'em. I said so all along. We didn't ought to 'ave trusted the buggers.'

But which buggers they didn't ought to have trusted Winston could not now remember.

Since about that time, war had been literally continuous, though strictly speaking it had not always been the same war. For several months during his childhood there had been confused street fighting in London itself, some of which he remembered vividly. But to trace out the history of the whole period, to say who was fighting whom at any given moment, would have been utterly impossible, since no written record, and no spoken word, ever made mention of any other alignment than the existing one. At this moment,

for example, in 1984 (if it was 1984), Oceania was at war with Eurasia and in alliance with Eastasia. In no public or private utterance was it ever admitted that the three powers had at any time been grouped along different lines. Actually, as Winston well knew, it was only four years since Oceania had been at war with Eastasia and in alliance with Eurasia. But that was merely a piece of furtive knowledge which he happened to possess because his memory was not satisfactorily under control. Officially the change of partners had never happened. Oceania was at war with Eurasia: therefore Oceania had always been at war with Eurasia. The enemy of the moment always represented absolute evil, and it followed that any past or future agreement with him was impossible.
The frightening thing, he reflected for the ten thousandth time as he forced his shoulders painfully backward (with hands on hips, they were gyrating their bodies from

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Winston was dreaming of his mother.
He must, he thought, have been ten or eleven years old when his mother had disappeared. She was a tall, statuesque, rather silent woman with slow movements and magnificent fair hair. His father he remembered more vaguely as dark and thin, dressed always in neat dark clothes (Winston remembered especially the very thin soles of his father's shoes) and wearing spectacles. The two of them must evidently have been swallowed up in one of the first great purges of the fifties.
At this moment his mother was sitting in some place deep down beneath him, with his young sister in her arms. He did not remember his sister at all, except as a tiny, feeble baby, always silent, with large, watchful eyes. Both of them were looking up at him. They were down in some subterranean place—the bottom of a well, for instance, or a very deep grave—but it was a place which, already far below him, was itself moving downwards. They were in the saloon of a sinking ship, looking up at him through the darkening water. There was still air in the saloon, they could still see him and he them, but all the while they were sinking down, down into the green waters which in another moment must hide them from sight for ever. He was out in the light and air while they were being sucked down to death, and they were down there because he was up here. He knew it and they knew it, and he could see the knowledge in their faces. There was no reproach either in their faces or in their hearts, only the knowledge that they must die in order that he might remain alive, and that this was part of the unavoidable order of things.
He could not remember what had happened, but he knew in his dream that in some way the lives of his mother and his sister had been sacrificed to his own. It was one of those dreams which, while retaining the characteristic dream scenery, are a continuation of one's intellectual life, and in which one becomes aware of facts and ideas which still seem new and valuable after one is

awake. The thing that now suddenly struck Winston was that his mother's death, nearly thirty years ago, had been tragic and sorrowful in a way that was no longer possible. Tragedy, he perceived, belonged to the ancient time, to a time when there was still privacy, love, and friendship, and when the members of a family stood by one another without needing to know the reason. His mother's memory tore at his heart because she had died loving him, when he was too young and selfish to love her in return, and because somehow, he did not remember

The telescreen struck fourteen. He must leave in ten minutes. He had to be back at work by fourteen-thirty.
Curiously, the chiming of the hour seemed to have put new heart into him. He was a lonely ghost uttering a truth that nobody would ever hear. But so long as he uttered it, in some obscure way the continuity was not broken. It was not by making yourself heard but by staying sane that you carried on the human heritage. He went back to the table, dipped his pen, and wrote:
To the future or to the past, to a time when thought is free, when men are different from one another and do not live alone—to a time when truth exists and what is done cannot be undone: From the age of uniformity, from the age of solitude, from the age of Big Brother, from the age of doublethink—greetings!
He was already dead, he reflected. It seemed to him that it was only now, when he had begun to be able to formulate his thoughts, that he had taken the decisive step. The consequences of every act are included in the act itself. He wrote:
Thoughtcrime does not entail death: thoughtcrime IS death.
Now he had recognized himself as a dead man it became important to stay alive as long as possible. Two fingers of his right hand were inkstained. It was exactly the kind of detail that might betray you. Some nosing zealot in the Ministry (a woman, probably: someone like the little sandy-haired woman or the dark-haired girl from the Fiction Department) might start wondering why he had been writing during the lunch interval, why he had used an old-fashioned pen, WHAT he had been writing—and then drop a hint in the appropriate quarter. He went to the bathroom and carefully scrubbed the ink away with the gritty dark-brown soap which rasped your skin like sandpaper and was therefore well adapted for this purpose.

He put the diary away in the drawer. It was quite useless to think of hiding it, but he could at least make sure whether or not its existence had been discovered. A hair laid across the page-ends was too obvious. With the tip of his finger he picked up an identifiable grain of whitish dust and deposited it on the corner of the cover, where it

was bound to be shaken off if the book was moved.
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1984
how, she had sacrificed herself to a conception of loyalty that was private and unalterable. Such things, he saw, could not happen today. Today there were fear, hatred, and pain, but no dignity of emotion, no deep or complex sorrows. All this he seemed to see in the large eyes of his mother and his sister, looking up at him through the green water, hundreds of fathoms down and still sinking.

Suddenly he was standing on short springy turf, on a summer evening when the slanting rays of the sun gilded the ground. The landscape that he was looking at recurred so often in his dreams that he was never fully certain whether or not he had seen it in the real world. In his waking thoughts he called it the Golden Country. It was an old, rabbit-bitten pasture, with a foot-track wandering across it and a molehill here and there. In the ragged hedge on the opposite side of the field the boughs of the elm trees were swaying very faintly in the breeze, their leaves just stirring in dense masses like women's hair. Somewhere near at hand, though out of sight, there was a clear, slow-moving stream where dace were swimming in the pools under the willow trees.

The girl with dark hair was coming towards them across the field. With what seemed a single movement she tore off her clothes and flung them disdainfully aside. Her body was white and smooth, but it aroused no desire in him, indeed he barely looked at it. What overwhelmed him in that instant was admiration for the gesture with which she had thrown her clothes aside. With its grace and carelessness it seemed to annihilate a whole culture, a whole system of thought, as though Big Brother and the Party and the Thought Police could all be swept into nothingness by a single splendid movement of the arm. That too was a gesture belonging to the ancient time. Winston woke up with the word 'Shakespeare' on his lips.

The telescreen was giving forth an ear-splitting whistle which continued on the same note for thirty seconds. It was nought seven fifteen, getting-up time for office workers. Winston wrenched his body out of bed-naked, for a member of the Outer Party received only 3,000 clothing coupons annually, and a suit of pyjamas was 600-and seized a dingy singlet and a pair of shorts that were lying across a chair. The Physical Jerks would begin in three minutes. The next moment he was doubled up by a violent coughing fit which nearly always attacked him soon after waking up. It emptied his lungs so completely that he could only begin breathing again by lying on his back and taking a series of deep gasps. His veins had swelled with the effort of the cough, and the varicose ulcer had started itching.
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